

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

(This is a two-page report. Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!

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CFO-RC FILE X:

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name): AMERICAN WOODCOCK		(Scientific Name) <i>Scolopax minor</i>
Date(s) of occurrence: 14 April 2000		
Number of birds seen: One	Sex: Male	Plumage: Adult
Exact Location: Rocky Ford State Wildlife Area		
County: Bent County	Nearest town: Fort Lyon	Elevation: 4150 msl
Length of observation: Roughly 15 minutes off and on		Time(s) of observation: Dusk
Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Tony Leukering, Chris Wood, Brandon Percival, Doug Faulkner, Mark Janos, Stan Oswald, and others. al.		
Other Observers who independently saw the bird(s):		
Light Conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s); position: Clear skies but dusk		
Optical equipment used: 8x40 Binoculars briefly		
Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): Varied between roughly 70 and 150 feet		
Was bird(s) photographed? No (but was audio-recorded)		If so, have you submitted photos?
Who took the photographs? Chris Wood tape-recorded the flight calls.		

Describe the general and specific habitat in which the bird(s) occurred: Riparian second-growth woodland and brushlands along the Arkansas River. Display area a typical grassy opening with small scattered shrubs (which had been recently burned).

Describe the bird's behavior (flying, feeding, habits, behaviors used in identifying the Species or in supporting the identification): See next section.

Describe the bird in detail. This is the most important part of this report. Include the overall size and shape and how you placed the bird in the general group that you did. Give complete details of plumage, including head, throat, undersides, nape, back, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird(s). Describe other important details, such as color and shape of bill, legs, eye, (etc.) that were important in making the identification. (Fill out this portion even if photographs are submitted; you may attach additional sheets, drawings, field sketches or copy field notes):

Stan Oswald reported a displaying male American Woodcock at the Rocky Ford State Wildlife Area. Arriving the next evening near dusk, a group of us stood by a small pond and watched the bird (silhouetted at best) actively engaged in breeding displays. The following were significant identification points from that night.

Size and Shape: The bird was only observed once on the ground. When on the ground, it was noticed to be a fat, chunky bird (almost quail-like) but with a large head with a no-necked appearance. In flight, this same heavy build was noticeable that was accentuated by broad, rounded wings (quite unlike other shorebirds). When plummeting back to the ground following its' display flight, I noticed a very long bill.

Having intensely studied the breeding displays of woodcock in northern Wisconsin, it was enjoyable to again witness the performance. When on the ground, the bird would call a distinct and emphatic nasal "peent" call, similar to that of a Common Nighthawk but seemingly not as discordant. These "peent" calls were delivered at roughly 10-second intervals. After a few minutes of this, the bird would fly, rising into the air and making a twittering call from its wings and would fly in upward spirals giving a melodic warbling call that increased in frequency as it rose (almost bat-like in its' squeaking pattern). After about 30 seconds of this display, the bird would tumble back towards the ground in erratic fashion with the wings producing a liquidy warble call. On its' return flight (which was mainly when the bird was visible due to the low light conditions), the flight was quick and fluttery (again, very bat-like). Once back on the singing ground, the bird would begin "peenting" again. We observed this entire sequence at least three if not four times. We departed when display activities appeared to subside due to darkness.

Describe bird's call or song: See above description

Discuss similar species and how you eliminated them: Snipe would be slimmer, have different calls, and would not undergo the same type of breeding displays.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? Have had considerable experience with the species. Have observed countless in Wisconsin and Minnesota and have also observed birds in Illinois, Kentucky, Tennessee, and Texas. Working for the Wisconsin Department of Natural Resources in Wisconsin, I used to conduct annual breeding woodcock population monitoring surveys for roughly a 10-year period.

List books, guides, recordings or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): None

This report is from notes made during or after XX observation or later from memory

Date of written report:

Reporting observer: Larry Semo

Signature:



Reporting Observer's Address: 9054 Dover Street

City: Westminster

State: Colorado

Zip: 80021

Send report to:
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